Uplifting the Tribals

Hirbai Ibrahim Lobi, *70*
Social activist



ONCE UPON A TIME in a Gujarat village, a young woman discovered that knowledge travels on airwaves when she chanced upon a voice explaining modern farming techniques on Akashvani. Struggling to make ends meet as a marginal farmer and labourer, Hirbai Lobi tilled the 0.5 hectares of land she inherited from her father. Not only did she utilise the information she heard on the radio, she also decided to spread this knowledge amongst women of her village Jambur, who chopped firewood—braving the lions of Gir—for a livelihood.

The inhabitants of Jambur are from the Siddi community—descendants of Africans who came to India centuries ago. Settled in remote areas, Siddis struggled with education and healthcare. "I was 25 when I first listened to Akashvani in Gujarati. I learnt how to open bank accounts, the need to educate children and use modern farming practices and fertilisers," she says.

The lessons she culled she sought to teach Siddi women—a tireless endeavour carried out with a missionary zeal. Over a period, Hirbai spread her work through 14 villages in Talala taluka in Junagadh district. There was a lot of resistance at first, and the women, wary of banks and schools, used to drive her away. But slowly, Hirbai's ideas found acceptance. In 2004, she started the Mahila Vikas Foundation, which helped women save in a cooperative model, hand out micro loans, offer counselling for women's issues as well as vocational courses like tailoring and the basics needed to run a grocery shop. Hirbai has helped thousands of Siddi women earn a livelihood and lead lives of dignity. It's due to her decades-long efforts that many Siddi children got an education. Hirbai herself lost her parents early and built on her education up to Class 2 through her trusted friend—the radio. Recognition for her life's work came in 2023, when she was awarded the Padma Shri.

"She helped thousands of women open bank accounts," says Hirbai's granddaughter Nargis. The young English literature graduate wants to continue her grandmother's work. Another of Hirbai's successes are Sakhi Mandals, where women save money and draw from it as a loan at nominal rates of interest. It is a form of banking women in these parts prefer the most. ■

–Jumana Shah

ACCOMPLISHMENT

Over four decades, her efforts have made Siddi tribal women self-reliant and led to the schooling of children in the community

ON LEADERSHIP

"It's about being fearless, leading from the front, speaking truth to power"

↘ THE BIG B CONNECT

She received the Reliance Real Award from Amitabh Bachchan

↘ SONGS THAT SOAK IN THE PAST

Hirbai is fond of folk music and sings songs that are a part of the Siddi folk dance Dhamaal